

Received Pronunciation *

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1. Finding a model

Early in the twentieth century Daniel Jones described the model accent presented in *An English Pronouncing Dictionary* as

that most usually heard in everyday speech in the families of Southern English persons whose men-folk have been educated at the great public [in the English sense of the word, i.e. private fee-paying] boarding-schools. This pronunciation is also used by a considerable proportion of those who do not come from the South of England, but who have been educated at these schools. The pronunciation may also be heard, to an extent which is considerable though difficult to specify, from persons of education in the South of England who have not been educated at these schools. It is probably accurate to say that a majority of those members of London society who have had a university education, use either this pronunciation or a pronunciation not differing very greatly from it. (Jones 1917: viii)

Jones's location of his model accent reflects social considerations of his time, with its reference to "men-folk" (then overwhelmingly the products of the public-school system) and the socially and economically dominant "London society", and emphasis on the normalizing force of *public school* education: indeed, so crucial is this element to his divination of his model that Jones initially calls it Public School Pronunciation, or PSP. Although non-Southerners might acquire the accent through privileged schooling, its possession is much more likely amongst educated Southerners.

Living in a hierarchical, south-east-focused and male-dominated world, Jones's stance on a model accent was understandable, and might be expected to have passed unquestioned in his day. Early twentieth-century assumptions are not necessarily ours, however: education is now more democratic in respect of both gender and class, and Southern England no longer holds a grip on linguistic prestige which it had on Britain a century ago. And to be fair to Jones, he himself was not completely locked into a narrow description of the accent. Despite the time-bound socio-cultural assumptions apparent in his description of his model, as the century progressed, although the essential prescription remained "public school" turned to "boarding school", "London society" became "Londoners", and by 1926 his label had become "Received Pronuncia-